

Peru



Once the heart of the Inca Empire, before the Spanish conquest in the 16th century, Peru lies on the Pacific coast of South America, just south of the equator.

**GEOGRAPHY**

Coastal plain rises to Andes Mountains. Uplands, dissected by fertile valleys, lie east of the Andes. Tropical forest in extreme east.

**CLIMATE**

Coast is mainly arid. Middle slopes of the Andes are temperate; higher peaks are snow-covered. East is hot, humid, and very wet.

**PEOPLE & SOCIETY**

Though most people are Amerindians or mixed-race *mestizos*, society is dominated by a small group of Spanish descendants. Amerindians, and the small black community, suffer discrimination in towns, but access to information and political power are growing; the first Amerindian president was elected in 2001–2006. Clashes with left-wing militants killed almost 70,000 people between 1980 and 2000.

**THE ECONOMY**

Abundant mineral resources: notably copper and gold. Rich Pacific fish stocks. Illegal cocaine producer.



INSIGHT: *Lake Titicaca is the world's highest navigable lake*

**FACTFILE**

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Peru

DATE OF FORMATION: 1824

CAPITAL: Lima

POPULATION: 29.2 million

TOTAL AREA: 496,223 sq. miles
(1,285,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 59 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Quechua*, Aymara

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 95%, other 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Amerindian 50%, *Mestizo* 40%, White 7%, other 3%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: New sol = 100 céntimos